

Crane Court

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Crane Court is a small lane just off Fleet Street, and although it looks rather uninteresting, it has a fascinating history.

For more than 130 years, from around 1590 to 1723, gallows stood near the entrance at Fetter Lane. In the early 1700s, Sir Isaac Newton and other scientists would have passed them on their way to the new home of the Royal Society in Crane Court. The Royal Society stayed there for about 70 years.

Crane Court was also connected with politics and printing. Political reformer John Wilkes became involved in a controversy when printer Dryden Leach, whose house stood in the court, was arrested for suspected seditious printing.

Two famous publications began in Crane Court: Punch magazine in 1841 and the Illustrated London News in 1842. The latter helped pioneer photojournalism.

Today, an orrery above the entrance remembers the lantern that once signalled when the Royal Society was meeting.

